covered. The high court has now called for a detailed investigation against ex-board officials.



SOMNATH, GUJARAT

The Shree Somnath Trust manages assets of Rs 600 crore and receives about Rs 35 lakh in donations daily. Money collected every day is reported to all trustees by evening and deposited in the bank the next morning. The SOP specifies who must be present when the cash box is opened, how cash moves within the premises, and how it is to be transferred to the bank. Trust's accounts are audited, and all stakeholders get an annual report.

KAMAKHYA, ASSAM



Kamakhya shows the limits of informal systems. Cash is collected, counted and maintained by the Bor-Doloi (chief priest) and his team; gold and other precious offerings are kept in the temple's traditional storehouse under designated functionaries. Audits are conducted every six months, but there is no publicly accessible report of donation totals or expenditure heads. Observers warn that excessive concentration of power and ad hoc systems are unsuitable for a large institution handling crores in offerings.



"It is not the job of the VHP in any part of the country to construct temples or to run them. The Trust would run them and what happens in the Trust would be the responsibility of the Trust"

—ALOK KUMAR
President, Vishva Hindu Parishad

Unheeded Warnings

In November 2020, nine months after the Trust was constituted, a private audit firm was engaged to review its working. After studying day-to-day administration, it had concluded that the Trust lacked a comprehensive protocol clearly defining responsibilities and establishing effective monitoring mechanisms. Without such a formal SOP, it warned, the system would remain fallible. Specifically, it flagged the poor recording of donations, lax monitoring of financial transactions and data, and went on to recommend separate registers for cash and jewellery donations, besides regular bank reconciliations overseen by qualified accounting professionals. Also, despite employing nearly 1,500 personnel, the Trust stuck to a personalised form of human resource management rather than professional screening.

Six years later, those words sting. Chief among the alleged culprits is Ram Shankar Yadav, alias Tinnu, a former driver of Champat Rai who is said to have acquired considerable clout owing to this proximity and apparently held the keys to the donation boxes and controlled the key counting operation personnel. The others arrested stand at lesser degrees on that patronage cline. Police raids on some of their residences as well as within temple precincts soon recovered stashes of cash totalling Rs 79.85 lakh—some of it even hidden inside temple bathrooms. Also seized were property documents reportedly adding up to a combined worth of about Rs 2 crore.

This picture broadly mirrors the account a former member of the counting team gave INDIA TODAY on the condition of anonymity. He had joined the process in March 2025 after approaching Rai, who referred him to Anil Mishra. A retired homeopath with roots in the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), Mishra and his wife had played *pradhan yajman* at the 2024 *pran pratishtha*, a ritual role that required a married couple. Last March, after a brief interview, Mishra had hired him and several others on Rs 15,000 a month, which later went up to Rs 18,000. "Our job was simple. We carried two or three donation boxes at a time to the counting room, emptied them, sorted the notes, tied them into bundles with rubber bands, and put them back in the boxes for machine counting," he said. One Trust representative, and another from SBI, were at hand.

The script, he alleges, strayed just weeks after they joined. "People wore kurtas, cargo pants, clothes with large pockets to the counting room. There were no rules. They could even bring others to assist with counting. Sometimes, forty to fifty people were involved," he claims. "We started noticing that many of the key employees, including those who are now arrested, were removing bundles, four or five of them, mostly of Rs 500 notes. Some of us confronted them, but they denied everything." He and several others eventually left. Meanwhile, allegations